



ANTOINE LAVOISIER

French chemist • 1743–1794

Chemists study substances, asking how they behave and what they are made of. Today, we know a lot of the answers. The periodic table lists all of the building blocks of the universe—the elements. But, when Antoine Lavoisier started his life in science, people were still arguing about what elements actually were.

Antoine began by studying air. He knew that it was involved in lots of different things, such as fire, breathing, and even the rusting of metals.

At the time, many people thought that fire itself was an element, called phlogiston, that was released when a substance caught fire. Antoine set out to prove that this idea was wrong.



Antoine studied reactions by collecting and weighing all the substances involved.

Theory of combustion

After almost 15 years and dozens of experiments, Antoine proved there is no such thing as phlogiston. He explained that burning is actually a fast chemical reaction between a fuel and oxygen in the air. This reaction is also known as combustion.

